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EXECUTIVE CORE QUALIFICATION NARRATIVES

Challenge • Context • Action • Result (CCAR) | Prepared for agency and QRB interviews

How to use: Under OPM's 2025 SES guidance, ECQ narratives are not submitted with the application; the two-page resume is the application and the ECQs are assessed through structured interviews. OPM allows candidates to refer to an outline during the QRB interview but discourages reading from a script. Use these narratives to prepare, then reduce each one to key points.

ECQ 1 COMMITMENT TO THE RULE OF LAW AND THE PRINCIPLES OF THE AMERICAN FOUNDING

Sub-competencies: *Knowledge of the American System of Government • Commitment to the Rule of Law • Civic-Mindedness*

Eliminating Anti-Deficiency Act violations across an $8.6B portfolio (FY2021–FY2025)

CHALLENGE

When I became Deputy CFO in April 2021, the Department had reported three Anti-Deficiency Act violations in FY2020. My challenge was to make sure every dollar of an $8.6B budget was spent only as Congress appropriated it: for the right purpose, in the right period, and within the right amount.

CONTEXT

Under the Constitution, Congress holds the power of the purse, and each Anti-Deficiency Act violation must be reported to the President and Congress, with a copy to GAO. Funds control depended on manual checks that varied by bureau, staff applied appropriations law unevenly, and the violations had damaged the Department's credibility with appropriations committees.

ACTION

- **First,** I traced each FY2020 violation to its root cause and found that obligations were being recorded before anyone confirmed funds were available for that purpose and period.
- **Second,** I built pre-obligation funds-control checks into the financial system, so a transaction could not post unless purpose, time, and amount were all verified.
- **Third,** I required legal review by the Solicitor's Office for any new or unusual use of funds, and trained 300+ budget and finance staff on appropriations law using GAO's Principles of Federal Appropriations Law.
- **Fourth,** I prepared the Assistant Secretary for six appropriations hearings, making sure every figure in testimony and budget justifications was accurate and fully supported, so Congress and the public could rely on it.

RESULT

- Zero Anti-Deficiency Act violations for five consecutive years, down from three in FY2020.
- Budget justifications passed committee review without a single corrected figure.
- The funds-control checks became the Department-wide standard for all bureaus.

ECQ 2 DRIVING EFFICIENCY

Sub-competencies: *Fiscal Responsibility • Managing Resources • Leveraging Technology*

Returning $112M to mission priorities and cutting the cost of finance operations (2021–2024)

CHALLENGE

I set out to cut the cost of the Department's finance operations and put idle money back to work for the mission, without adding staff.

CONTEXT

Four bureaus ran separate accounting operations with duplicate systems and staff. Unobligated and expiring balances were not reviewed systematically, so money sat unused until it lapsed. Fund Balance with Treasury reconciliations were done by hand and took 15 days each month, tying up skilled accountants in routine work.

ACTION

- **Fiscal responsibility:** I directed a bureau-wide review of every unobligated and expiring balance, ranked each by mission value, and worked with OMB and congressional committees to reprogram funds where the law allowed.
- **Managing resources:** I made the business case for consolidating four bureau accounting operations into one shared service center and led the transition, reassigning staff to analysis and audit work rather than reducing service.
- **Leveraging technology:** I championed robotic process automation for Fund Balance with Treasury reconciliations, requiring a security review and documented internal controls for every bot before launch.

RESULT

- Recovered $112M and reprogrammed it to priority missions with OMB and congressional approval.
- Cut cost per transaction 27%, saving $9.4M per year.
- Saved 22,000 staff-hours a year and cut the reconciliation cycle from 15 days to 3.

ECQ 3 MERIT AND COMPETENCE

Sub-competencies: *Technical Skill • Problem Solving • Agility and Resilience*

Earning the Department's first unmodified audit opinion in six years (FY2021–FY2023)

CHALLENGE

The Department had received a modified audit opinion for six straight years because of two material weaknesses: property, plant, and equipment, and Fund Balance with Treasury. I was charged with fixing both.

CONTEXT

The weaknesses had survived several earlier remediation plans. Property records across bureaus did not match the general ledger, and $210M in undelivered orders lacked supporting documentation. Midway through the effort, Congress passed a $1.3B emergency supplemental that required new controls and DATA Act reporting immediately.

ACTION

- **Applied technical expertise:** As a CPA and CGFM, I personally reviewed the auditors' findings with the Inspector General's team and built a corrective action plan with specific owners, test steps, and deadlines for each deficiency.
- **Found the root cause:** Using transaction data, I traced the unsupported undelivered orders to weak obligation documentation and built a data-driven validation process that every bureau now runs each quarter.
- **Adapted under pressure:** When the supplemental arrived, I stood up separate tracking codes and controls within 10 days, protecting the remediation schedule while meeting the new reporting requirements.

RESULT

- Cleared both material weaknesses in two audit cycles and earned the first unmodified opinion in six years.
- Deobligated $58M in stale funds through the validation process.
- Delivered complete, on-time DATA Act reporting for the $1.3B supplemental.

ECQ 4 LEADING PEOPLE

Sub-competencies: *Accountability • Developing Others • Executive Judgment*

Rebuilding a 140-person finance workforce around skill and accountability (2021–2025)

CHALLENGE

I inherited a finance organization of 140 accountants, budget analysts, and auditors in which only 62% of month-end closes were on time, attrition was 16%, and fewer than one in five staff held a professional credential.

CONTEXT

Experienced staff were retiring, standards varied across five divisions, and some long-running performance problems had never been addressed. With audit remediation underway, the Department could not afford late or inaccurate books.

ACTION

- **Set clear accountability:** I gave each of my eight supervisors measurable accuracy and timeliness standards and reviewed results with them every month.
- **Acted on performance:** I addressed chronic performance gaps directly through improvement plans and, where results did not follow, reassignments.
- **Developed others:** I recruited 26 credentialed professionals, sponsored CPA and CGFM certification for current staff, and created rotations so analysts learned budget, accounting, and audit work.
- **Used executive judgment:** I chose to protect training funding during a tight budget year, reasoning that a skilled workforce was the only lasting fix for audit findings, and explained that decision to staff and leadership.

RESULT

- On-time month-end close rose from 62% to 98%.
- Certified staff grew from 18% to 41% of the workforce.
- Attrition fell from 16% to 8%.

ECQ 5 ACHIEVING RESULTS

Sub-competencies: *Operational Mindset • Innovation • Strategic Thinking*

Delivering the Secretary's cost-reduction directive at 104% of goal (FY2022–FY2025)

CHALLENGE

In 2022 the Secretary directed the Department to cut recurring costs without reducing core services. I was asked to turn that directive into results.

CONTEXT

Bureaus had no shared targets or method for finding savings, and many programs were funded each year based on the prior year's level rather than on results. Bureau leaders worried that cuts would fall on their missions.

ACTION

- **Strategic thinking:** I translated the directive into a three-year plan with savings targets for every bureau, set according to each bureau's spending patterns and mission risk.
- **Innovation:** I introduced zero-based reviews for 38 programs, requiring each to justify its funding from the ground up against measurable outcomes.
- **Operational mindset:** I tracked progress monthly with bureau finance leaders, removed obstacles such as conflicting guidance, and reported results to the Secretary each quarter.

RESULT

- Achieved $64M in recurring savings, 104% of the goal.
- Ended six low-performing programs and redirected $47M to higher-return priorities.
- The zero-based review method was built into the Department's annual budget process.